

SARAH ASHCROFT-JONES

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RESEARCH SUMMARY

Behavioral and cognitive decision scientist with a DPhil in Experimental Psychology and a strong record of research-led teaching across undergraduate and graduate contexts. Research spans judgment and decision-making, financial cognition, metacognition, and cross-national behavioral variation. Focused on applying rigorous psychological science to diverse fields using advanced methodological approaches.

SELECTED FIRST-AUTHOR PAPERS

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Ruggeri, K.⁺, Abate Romero Landini, G. *et al.* The persistence of cognitive biases in financial decisions across economic groups. *Sci Rep* **13**, 10329, (2023). DOI: 10.1038/s41598-023-36339-2

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Yao, Q.⁺, Pei, S., & Ruggeri, K. Person, place, or preference? Combining subjective and objective decision agency with choice preferences predicts behavior during major shifts in human mobility. *under review*, (2026)
Preprint DOI: 10.1101/2025.09.08.25335351 (2025)

Ashcroft-Jones, S., Pelica, S., & Ruggeri, K. The role of assets in the income-well-being relationship – a double-edged moderator? *under review*, (2026)

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Buabang, E. K.⁺, & Ruggeri, K. Better data, better policy: Distinguishing income poverty and financial stress may promote better temporal decision-making. *under review*, (2026)
Preprint DOI: 10.31234/osf.io/vkfhv.v1 (2026)

Ashcroft-Jones, S., & Yeung, N. Confidence in categorical decisions: the role of category variance under uncertainty. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Ashcroft-Jones, S., Ruggeri, K., & Di, X. When the rubber meets the (rail)road: Policy implications of time, health, and pricing salience in NYC public transit. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

EDUCATION

The Queen's College, University of Oxford Oct 2019 - Nov 2023
DPhil in Experimental Psychology, Oxford ACCLab Funded by the MRC DTP
Thesis: "Exploring metacognitive confidence in categorisation judgements"

St. Cross College, University of Oxford Oct 2018 - Sept 2019
MSc in Psychological Research Humphrey Prize for Best Research Dissertation
Thesis: "Computing confidence: the role of category representation and perceptual uncertainty"

St. John's College, University of Cambridge Oct 2014 - Jun 2017
MA Cantab in Psychological and Behavioural Sciences The Cambridge Double First
Scholar of St. John's, Alfred Hall Prior Scholarship, Wright Prize

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Columbia University, Mailman School of Public Health

Associate Research Scientist - Health Policy & Management

Feb 1st 2025 - Present

- Lead research on how digital and AI-mediated systems influence real-world financial decisions.
- Design and analyze large-scale observational and experimental studies in R and Python, translating complex behavioral data into actionable insights.
- Co-develop and evaluate applied interventions, including AI-assisted savings support and chatbot-based and personalized behavioral interventions with external partners.

Columbia University, Mailman School of Public Health

Postdoctoral Researcher - Health Policy & Management

Nov 16th 2023 - Feb 1st 2025

- Designed and executed behavioral science studies on financial and health behaviors, combining experimental methods, survey research, and quantitative analysis.
- Investigated how individual and structural factors shape decision-making under uncertainty.
- Collaborated across interdisciplinary teams to generate evidence for academic and applied audiences.

World Bank Group

Research Consultant - Mind, Behavior & Development Unit

Oct 2022 - Nov 2023

- Conducted large-scale evidence synthesis to inform policy and program design for global stakeholders.
- Translated behavioral findings into actionable recommendations for policymakers and governments.
- Produced audience-sensitive research outputs connecting empirical evidence to intervention and policy.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Columbia University - Lecturer

Jan 2024 - Present

Course Lead - AI Interventions for Health Policy (Upcoming - Spring Semester 2027):

- Developing a new graduate course on critically evaluating AI interventions in health policy.
- Combining discussion with intervention construction to build critical thinking and practical skill set.
- Establishing curriculum, sourcing funding, building assignments, and setting competencies.

Course Lead - Managerial and Organizational Behavior (Fall Semester 2026 - Present):

- Leading a seminar-based graduate course on organisational psychology and its applications to the health administration context, focused on teaching professional students with unique learning needs.
- Combining discussion sessions and theoretical lectures to build student acumen.
- Establishing curriculum, assignments, and grading.

Course Lead - Global Behavioral Science - GLOBES (Fall Semester 2024 - Present):

- Directing an immersive international research practicum at the University of Cambridge, in which students produce a complete research manuscript end-to-end over three weeks.
- Establishing a flat knowledge hierarchy across students from diverse disciplinary and national backgrounds, positioning diversity as a methodological asset.
- Responsible for curriculum design, budget acquisition, research oversight, and logistical coordination.

Course Lead - Computing in Context using Python (Fall Semester 2024 - Present):

- Leading a skills-based graduate course on Python and its applications to the health policy context.
- Combining practical labs and theoretical lectures to build student analytic acumen.
- Establishing curriculum, assignments, and grading for Public Health Context.

Course Lead - Graduate Analytics Course in Public Health (Jan 2024 - May 2025):

- Co-leading analytics course to class of 50 students, overseeing assignments and examinations.
- Cultivating an analytic mindset and communicating statistical theory and practice.
- Includes workshops on statistical programming in R and JASP software for analysis.

University of Oxford - Graduate Teacher

Oct 2020 - Oct 2023

Lab Demonstrator (Oct 2020 - Oct 2023):

- Assisted core practical demonstrations and marking coursework.
- Graded coursework, supervised classwork, and helped students understand the learning outcomes.
- *Courses:* Perception, Development, Individual Differences, Social Psych, Ethics, & Qual Methods.

Teaching Assistant (Oct 2022 - Dec 2022):

- Assisted on the graduate course “Quantitative Methods” for MSc in Experimental Anthropology.
- Course content focused on learning the skills of Statistical Programming in R.
- Assisted students during class, held weekly office hours, and supported the course leader throughout.

Undergraduate Supervisor (Oct 2020 - Dec 2022):

- Supervised undergraduate tutorial groups for the Introductory Psychology and Cognition course.
- Explored course content, taught essay writing skills, and developed understanding of complex topics.
- Adjusted teaching style to suit the needs of the students and their learning goals.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Judgment & decision-making, metacognition, financial cognition, quantitative methods, measurement

PUBLICATIONS

Ruggeri, K., Valenzuela-Catari, G., Polemiti, E., Abderahaman, G., Adawi, T. R., Agopian, T., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., Pelica. Global well-being in 2025: A multidimensional analysis of mental, financial, and social health in 92 countries. *In Press* (2026)
Preprint DOI: 10.31234/osf.io/3jydav1 (2025)

Azevedo, F., Friedel, E., Ashcroft-Jones, S., Korbmacher, M., Lloyd, K., Mudahera, D. R., Krasteva, A., Resulbegoviq, H., Andreolli, G., Micheli, L., & Silverstein, P. . “6: How to... develop and use Open Educational Resources”. In *Teaching Open Science*. Cheltenham, UK: Edward Elgar Publishing (2026)
DOI: 10.4337/9781035359066.00014

van den Akker, O. R., Bakker, M., van Assen, M. A., Pennington, C. R., Verweij, L., Elsherif, M. M., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... & Wicherts, J. M. The potential of pre-registration in psychology: Assessing preregistration producibility and preregistration-study consistency. *Psychological Methods* (2024)
DOI: 10.1037/met0000687

Ruggeri, K., Stock, F., Haslam, S.A., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... *et al.* A synthesis of evidence for policy from behavioural science during COVID-19. *Nature* (2023).
DOI: 10.1038/s41586-023-06840-9

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Ruggeri, K.⁺, Abate Romero Landini, G. *et al.* The persistence of cognitive biases in financial decisions across economic groups. *Sci Rep* 13, 10329, (2023).

DOI: 10.1038/s41598-023-36339-2

Ruggeri, K., Tutuska, O.S., ... & Ashcroft-Jones, S. The psychology and policy of overcoming economic inequality. *Behavioural and Brain Sciences*, (2023).

DOI: 10.1017/S0140525X23001103

Pownall, M., Azevedo, F., König, L. M., Slack, H. R., Evans, T. R., Flack, Z., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... & FORRT. Teaching open and reproducible scholarship: a critical review of the evidence base for current pedagogical methods and their outcomes. *Royal Society Open Science*, 10(5), 221255, (2023).

DOI: 10.1098/rsos.221255

Buabang, E. K., Ashcroft-Jones, S., Esteban Serna, C., Kastelic, K., Kveder, J., Lambertus, A., Müller, T. S. Validation and Measurement Invariance of the Personal Financial Wellness Scale: A Multinational Study in 7 Countries, *European Journal of Psychological Assessment*, (2022).

DOI: 10.1027/1015-5759/a000750

Parsons, S., Azevedo, F., Elsherif, M.M., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... *et al.* A community-sourced glossary of open scholarship terms, *Nat Hum Behav.* (2022).

DOI: 10.1038/s41562-021-01269-4

Ruggeri, K., Panin, A., Vdovic, M., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... *et al.* The globalizability of temporal discounting. *Nat Hum Behav*, (2022).

DOI: 10.1038/s41562-022-01392-w

Ruggeri, K., Većkalov, B., Bojanić, L., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... *et al.* The general fault in our fault lines. *Nat Hum Behav*, (2021).

DOI: 10.1038/s41562-021-01092-x

Eckstein, M., Zietlow, A., Gerchen, M.F., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... *et al.*, The NeMo real-time fMRI neurofeedback study: protocol of a randomised controlled clinical intervention trial in the neural foundations of mother–infant bonding, *BMJ Open*, (2019).

DOI: 10.1136/bmjopen-2018-027747

PAPERS UNDER REVIEW

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Yao, Q.⁺, Pei, S., & Ruggeri, K. Person, place, or preference? Combining subjective and objective decision agency with choice preferences predicts behavior during major shifts in human mobility. *under review*, (2026)

Preprint DOI: 10.1101/2025.09.08.25335351 (2025)

Kovacs, L. N., Ashcroft-Jones, S., Schmidt, J., Geiger, S., ... Kokonyei, G. Loss-and gain-framed messages alter climate emotions, but not behaviour across 26 countries. *under review*, (2026)

Preprint DOI: 10.31234/osf.io/4kqamv1 (2025)

Roth, L. H. O., Tissot, T. T. Neebar, A. I. K., Hamilton, A. A., Campanella, F., Sosliuk, H., Lange, M. C., Vraničar, I., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S. ... Is Effort Moralization a Function of Cognitive Fatigue? A Multi-Country Test of Fatigue as a Moderator of Moral Judgments of Others' Effort. *Stage 2 Registered Report, Stage 1 accepted*, (2026)
Accepted Stage 1 Report: osf.io/exgm6/ (2025)

Stock, F., Pelica, S., Ashcroft-Jones, S., Stablum, F., Acosta, C., Aimable, A., *et al.* People in 26 countries prefer individual control to commercial or governmental control over online choice architectures. *under review*, (2026)
Preprint DOI: [10.31219/osf.io/haqu9](https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/haqu9) (2024)

Ashcroft-Jones, S., Pelica, S., & Ruggeri, K. The role of assets in the income-well-being relationship – a double-edged moderator? *under review*, (2026)

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Buabang, E. K.⁺, & Ruggeri, K. Better data, better policy: Distinguishing income poverty and financial stress may promote better temporal decision-making. *under review*, (2026)
Preprint DOI: [10.31234/osf.io/vkfhp-v1](https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/vkfhp-v1) (2026)

Ruggeri, K., DEVIATE Collaborators, & S., Ashcroft-Jones, S. Applying positive deviance in behavioral interventions to improve health and financial decision-making: The DEVIATE Study. *under review*, (2026)

Ruggeri, K., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S. New money, no money, and psychological inheritance in the elasticity of 21st century happiness. *under review*, (2026)

WORKING PAPERS

Ashcroft-Jones, S., & Yeung, N. Confidence in categorical decisions: the role of category variance under uncertainty. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Ashcroft-Jones, S.⁺, Nga Yu Au, I.⁺, & Feldman, G. Revisiting “Goals as Reference Points”: Replication and extension of Heath et al. (1999) *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Ruggeri, K., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., Stock, F. Financial decision-making, income, cognitive biases: The impact of economic systems and environments on behavior in six countries. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026).
Preprint DOI: [10.31219/osf.io/f8hyk](https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/f8hyk) (2024)

Ashcroft-Jones, S., Ruggeri, K., & Di, X. When the rubber meets the (rail)road: Policy implications of time, health, and pricing salience in NYC public transit. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Geiger, S., Sabherwal, A., ... Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... & Weber, E. Conversations with AI influence climate policy opinions across 24 countries. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Jarke, H., Ashcroft-Jones, S., ... & Ruggeri, k. How EU doin'? The Relationship of Mental Well-Being and Depression in the EU. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Soboleva, I., Ruggeri, I., Pelica, S., Ashcroft-Jones, S., Meyer, S. Mental Toll of Economic Pessimism: Applying Prospect Theory to Financial Outlook and Well-Being in 92 Countries *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

Donicke, J., ... & Ashcroft-Jones, S. Is the socioeconomic gradient in mental well-being weaker in more equal European countries? A multilevel analysis of economic inequality, social safety, and mental well-being. *Manuscript in preparation*, (2026)

POSTERS & PRESENTATIONS

Ashcroft-Jones, S., & Ruggeri, K. “Personalized, simple defaults to optimize financial decisions in a digital budgeting tool, a pre-test”

Poster: Max Planck Institute for Human Development, Berlin, June 2025

Ashcroft-Jones, S. & Pelica, S. “Reproducible Data Processing and Analysis using R and Quarto.”

Workshop: Kurt Lewin Instituut, March 2025

Ashcroft-Jones, S. “Behavioural Science in health and financial research.”

Presentation: UCL Behavioural Innovations Society, London, January 2025

Ashcroft-Jones, S. & Ruggeri, K. “Personalized, simple defaults using a positive deviance approach to optimize financial decisions.”

Poster: Society of Judgement and Decision Making, New York, November 2024

Ashcroft-Jones, S., “Open Science & Reproducibility: A practical introduction & a personal perspective.”

Presentation: MRC DTP Discussion Forum, Oxford, April 2023

Ashcroft-Jones, S. & Yeung, N., “Decision Confidence: Exploring the Distance-to-Bound Model of Confidence.”

Poster: ICPS, Brussels, March 2023

Ashcroft-Jones, S., “A multinational study exploring the relationship between poverty, stress, financial literacy, and decision making.”

Presentation: JRPC, Cambridge, August 2022

Ashcroft-Jones, S. & Yeung, N., “Decision confidence is sensitive to both distribution variance and distance to the category bound.”

Poster: MRC DTP Symposium, Oxford, June & JRP Open Conference, Siena, July 2022

Ashcroft-Jones, S., “Category information and confidence sensitivity: Beyond distance to bound.”

Presentation: Experimental Psychology DPhil Seminar Series, Oxford, May 2022

Ashcroft-Jones, S., “Open Science & Reproducibility: A practical introduction.”

Presentation: MRC DTP Discussion Forum, Oxford, March 2022

Ashcroft-Jones, S., Calder-Travis, J., & Yeung, N., “Computing Decision Confidence: The role of category membership and perceptual uncertainty.”

Poster: JRPC, Cambridge, August 2019: <https://osf.io/7vwb4>

Buabang, E. K., Ashcroft-Jones, S., Esteban Serna, C., Kastelic, K., Kveder, J., Lambertus, A., & Müller, T. S., “The poverty trap: A multinational study examining the relationship between poverty, decision making, stress, and well-being.”

Poster: UFV Madrid JRP Meeting, Madrid, March 2019: <https://osf.io/f5k6c>

GRANTS & FUNDING

Despard, M. (co-PI), Trevino, J. (co-PI), Ruggeri, K. (co-PI), & Ashcroft-Jones, S. (co-I). Applying ML & Gen AI to Boost the Financial Security. GITLAB (~\$30,000 sub-grant to co-Is via SAVERLIFE) - awarded (2026)

Ashcroft-Jones, S. (MPI), Yao, Q. (MPI), & Pei, S. (co-I). A behaviorally informed AI simulator of older populations to reduce hurricane-related mortality. NIH R21 - pending (2026)

Ruggeri, K. (PI), & Ashcroft-Jones, S. (co-I). Piloting a 25-year study on the impact of childhood development accounts on long-term mental health and well-being. CUIMC Healthy Aging Initiative (CHAI) - pending (2026)

Ruggeri, K. (PI), & Ashcroft-Jones, S. (co-I). INHERTIA: Psychological inheritance and inertia accounts for optimal financial decision-making to increase population well-being. NSF DRMC - pending (2026)

Ruggeri, K. (PI), Ashcroft-Jones, S. (co-I), & Pelica, S. (co-I). FUTEARN: Enabling future prosperity and earning potential of America’s youth. Anthropic - pending (2026)

Lee, Y. (PI), ... Ashcroft-Jones, S. (co-I). Developing and Validating a Measure of Post-Study Engagement. PCORI - pending (2026)

AWARDS

2025	Best Poster at MPI for Human Development, Berlin (~ \$500)
2022	UKRI DTP Research Stay at Cambridge University (~ \$3,500)
2021	UKRI COVID DTP Studentship Extension (~ \$7,500)
2019	UKRI Medical Research Council DTP Studentship (3 years) (~ \$75,000)
2019	The Humphrey Dissertation Prize (~ \$200)
2017	Alfred Hall Prior Scholarships & Wright Prizes (~ \$2,500)

LEADERSHIP

Junior Researcher Programme

Oct 2019 - Present

Executive Director

- Leading a global research organisation running large-scale studies across 20+ countries.
- Providing an ongoing infrastructure for replicable, population-diverse experimental research.
- Secured new institutional partnerships establishing sustainable cross-university collaborations.
- Manage 6 ECR research teams, and one large-scale cross-border project, across 13-month program.
- Execute funding budget, lead team of 15, and iterate annual calendar of international events.

Framework for Open and Reproducible Research Training

Dec 2024 - Present

Director of Sustainability & Strategy

- Strategic reimagining of open science infrastructure via multi-stakeholder governance models.
- Structuring a multi-layer funding pipeline to ensure the sustainable growth of community research.
- Organisational support for projects relating to replication science and open pedagogy.

RESEARCH SKILLS

Programming Skills

R, Python, MatLab, JavaScript, HTML, CSS.

Software & Tools

L^AT_EX, RMarkdown, JASP, Tableau, SPSS, NVivo, ATLAS.

Computational Training

ASSP 2024, ESS Bayesian Analysis, SysMIC Module 1 (Hons).

Languages

English (C2), Irish (C1), German (B2), French (A2), Japanese (A2).

SERVICE

Cambridge University

Oct 2024 - Present

Research Associate - Centre for Business Research, Judge Business School

- Organising annual international behavioural research projects spanning multiple countries.
- Responsible for the logistical coordination of a three-week research stay for almost 40 researchers.
- Liaising with Corpus Christi, Judge Business, and the JRP to coordinate.

Academic Journals

Oct 2023 - Present

Peer Reviewer & Editorial Board Member

- Serve as an ad hoc peer reviewer for multiple journals, providing commentary insight to the editors.
- Journals reviewed span the Journal of Financial Services Marketing, Reproducible Research, and Teaching Psychology.
- Serve as an Editorial Board Member for the Journal of Multidisciplinary Healthcare

The Forum on Education Abroad

Sept 2025 - Present

Faculty Reviewer

- Served as a faculty reviewer for the Award for Academic Achievement Abroad.
- Assessed student contributions and potential for future research.

Reproducible Research Oxford

Oct 2020 - Nov 2023

RROx Fellow

- Supporting local Open Science initiatives, leading lectures and groups, and building community.
- Established a long-running bookclub for skill acquisition and ECR community engagement.
- Gave annual MRC DTP open science lecture.

ReproducibiliTea

Oct 2019 - Nov 2023

Oxford Local Lead

- Organising the regular reproducibiliTea journal club: leading local sessions and workshops.
- Building term cards of journal club sessions and acquiring local funding for the initiative.
- Leading team and creating community among ECRs.